study that restored the Vijayanagara empire of the little-known Sangama dynasty of Karnataka to history.[7]

Rea also deserves more than a pat on the back for his surveying of what has since come to be recognised as the 'Krishna River Civilisation': a predominantly Buddhist culture that appeared quite suddenly in that area in the second century BCE, and ended almost as suddenly in the third century CE – dates that more or less match the rise and fall of the Satavahana empire and its hugely profitable trade with the Western world.

What was left of the Amaravati stupa had already been explored by Mackenzie and others but Sewell carried out a more thorough excavation, resulting in further finds that now grace the Chennai Museum. He then worked his way along the banks of the Krishna River examining other potential sites, one of which was a large mound near the little village of Bhattiprolu, 80 kilometres downstream from Amaravati. This also had been plundered for its building material, although in this case the culprit was the officer in charge of the local Public Works Department, who had used its slabs to make a sluice gate for a nearby canal. However, the foundations were untouched, leading to the recovery of three untouched stone receptacles, each containing small reliquary caskets of copper, silver, gold and crystal as well as tiny bone fragments. The reliquaries carried a total of ten short inscriptions written in early Brahmi, all but one lacking the usual diacriticals used to distinguish between vowel sounds, as well as employing other previously unknown characters. Rea speculated that this was a local variant of Brahmi, which it was afterwards shown to be – an embryonic version of the Telangana script, written in the second century BCE.

However, Rea missed one prime site: Nagarjunakonda. This only came to light in 1926 when A. R. Saraswati, the Telugu language expert in the Madras Department of